The wars particularly against Austria, Prussia and later England engaged Republican France. As a consequence it was not possible to deal with local social problems.

In order to depart totally from the ancient regime, the Convention created a new Republican calendar for France. All references to religion found in the old calendar's name were deleted, and a 10-day week followed. In this secular calendar, the twelve months of the year were named after natural elements, while each day was named after a seed, tree, flower, fruit, animal, or tool, replacing the saints'-day names and Christian festivals. (The republican calendar was abandoned by Napoleon on 1 January 1806.) The existing system of measures was replaced by a metric system based on the kilogram and the metre.

In September 1793 the Convention passed the Law of Suspects, which authorized the arrest of persons suspected of opposing the revolution. A month later twenty two Girondins' deputies of the Convention were tried by the Revolutionary Tribunal and sentenced to death. Thus began the 'Reign of Terror'.

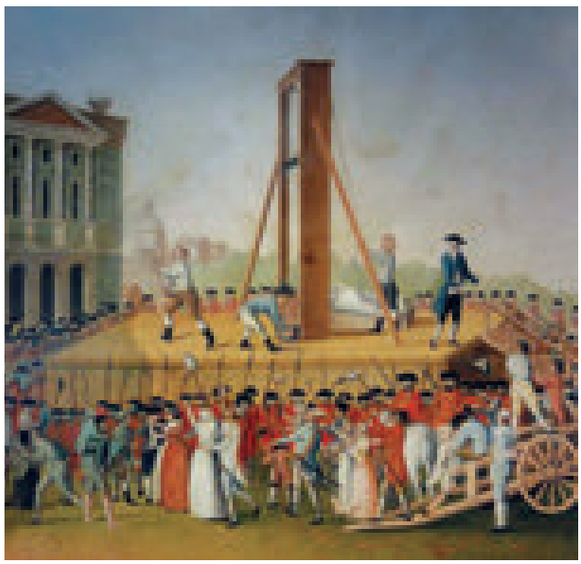


Robespierre

Danton, Herbert and Robespierre emerged as the main leaders of the National Convention. However, they were divided on many issues. Robespierre controlled the Committee of Public Safety and eliminated his rivals. There was a massive peasant revolt in the Vendee partly because of the unwillingness of the peasantry to accept conscriptions. The Vendee revolt was suppressed with great cruelty. There was a strong movement against Christianity. The proponents of this movement proposed the worship of Reason. There was great Festival of Liberty and Reason in Notre Dame Cathedral in Paris. But Robespierre was conservative in religious matters and neither he nor Danton approved of this movement. Herbert and his supporters who had organized the festival were sent to the guillotine. This caused the first split in the Jacobin party.

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Danton and others protested against Robespierre for sending too many people to the guillotine. But they were also executed. Surrounded by enemies and totally alienated from the people, Robespierre and his clique chose to intensify the Terror.



Guillotine

The Law of Suspects made spreading of false news to divide or instigate the people a punishable crime. Under this Law, large groups of persons were tried together and sentenced. This Terror lasted for forty six days. On 27 July 1794, the Convention suddenly turned against Robespierre and his supporters. The next day Robespierre was sent to the guillotine.

The Reign of Terror ended with the fall of Robespierre. Robespierre, the dictator of the Convention, though he was honest, patriotic and a person of integrity, earned notoriety by sending many of his colleagues to the guillotine. In October 1795 the Convention broke up and a Directory of five members assumed power.

The Directory was short lived and was replaced by the Consulate with Napoleon

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